

2009

2010

173

THE NUMBER OF DEATHS IN THE VICTORIA BUSH FIRES

FOLLOWING AIR STRIKES THE PREVIOUS YEAR,

Israeli troops invaded Gaza in early January. Israel claimed it was in an attempt to stop **Hamas**, the main Islamic resistance movement, from firing rockets into Israel. A ceasefire was declared and Israeli troops withdrew from Gaza by the end of January.

Right-wing activists in the US calling themselves the **Tea Party** roared onto the political scene this year, demanding fiscal responsibility and lower taxes.

American car giants **General Motors** and **Chrysler** both filed for **bankruptcy** in 2009, as the ongoing financial crisis took its toll on industries around the world.

Zimbabwe's opposition leader **Morgan Tsvangirai** (b. 1952) was sworn in as prime minister in a unity government with President Robert Mugabe on February 11. This power-sharing deal was designed to put an end to the ongoing political violence in Zimbabwe.

The **Copenhagen climate summit** was held in December. Five nations, including China and the US, agreed to attempt to limit global temperature rises. Some critics were disappointed, as they thought that the agreement did not go far enough.

Swiss tennis player **Roger Federer** won the men's tennis final at Wimbledon in July; it was his 15th Grand Slam win, and made him the most successful men's tennis player in Grand Slam history.



BP workers lay an oil absorbent boom near a wildlife refuge off the Gulf of Mexico to stop the spread of oil from the Deepwater Horizon platform disaster.



Spread of volcanic ash in Europe
The constantly shifting high-altitude cloud of volcanic ash from Eyjafjallajökull, Iceland, caused travel chaos as European airspace was closed.

KEY
19th April 0000 GMT
19th April 0600 GMT

AN EARTHQUAKE DEVASTATED the Haitian capital **Port au Prince** on January 12. It measured 7 on the Richter scale, and around 230,000 people died. Many were housed in badly constructed buildings.

An **Icelandic volcano**, dormant for two hundred years, erupted near the Eyjafjallajökull glacier on April 14. It sent clouds of ash soaring as high as 36,000 ft (11,000 m), disrupting air traffic in Europe, and delaying millions of air passengers across the world.

The **US** experienced an **environmental disaster** in April when the BP-owned **Deepwater Horizon** oil rig exploded and sank. Around four million barrels of oil were pumped into the Gulf of Mexico and 11 men were killed.

At the **UN climate summit** held in Cancun, Mexico, a new fund was created to give money to developing countries trying to tackle the consequences of climate change.

Poland was plunged into mourning when President Lech Kaczynski, his wife Maria, and other senior Polish figures were killed in a **plane crash** in Russia on April 10.

The global recession continued, and the **Greek economy** faced the threat of bankruptcy. On May 2, the International Monetary Fund (IMF) agreed to a €110 billion loan for Greece, on the condition that **austerity** measures were enforced. **Ireland** asked the European Union for a **rescue**

finance package on November 21, after seven days of denying it needed a bailout for its banking system. People across Europe held **demonstrations** on September 29, protesting at austerity measures made by their governments. They were particularly angry at the vast sums of money that had been used to rescue **banks**.

The world held its breath in late November as **North Korea** bombarded a South Korean island near a disputed maritime border, leaving two soldiers dead. The clash was one of the most serious since the end of the Korean War (see 1950). War was not declared, but tensions continued to simmer.

Burma's military regime released pro-democracy leader **Aung San Suu Kyi** (see panel, below) on November 13.

The imprisoned Chinese dissident **Liu Xiaobo** won this year's **Nobel Peace Prize**. The ceremony was boycotted by China, which launched an unprecedented campaign against the award.



Chilean rescue

A Chilean miner is helped to the surface after being trapped underground for 10 weeks following the collapse of the San José mine.

On August 5, 33 **Chilean miners** were trapped underground following a cave-in. They spent 69 days in the mine and the world became transfixed by their ordeal and successful rescue, which was completed on October 14.

AUNG SAN SUU KYI (1945–)



Burmese opposition leader Aung San Suu Kyi spent most of the previous 20 years under house arrest, due to her efforts to bring democracy to Burma. Her tireless determination to stand for nonviolent resistance in the face of a brutal military regime inspired the world. She was released from house arrest in 2010 and called for "national conciliation."

